



BEFORE

New Orleans had seen rapid expansion of trade and growing prosperity in the years leading up to the Civil War. It also occupied a vital strategic location on the Mississippi.

MULTIPLE UNION THREATS

Despite its importance to the Confederacy, **New Orleans had reduced its defenses** because of the Union threat to the north in Tennessee, where General Ulysses S. [Grant was advancing on forts Henry and Donelson](#). Both land and naval forces had been dispatched northward, including eight ships of the River Defense Fleet.

SEABORNE LANDINGS

Union experience of amphibious warfare early in the war led it to believe that **New Orleans** could be taken by a **seaborne operation**. Both at Hatteras Inlet, North Carolina, in August 1861, and the following November at Port Royal, South Carolina, **Union warships** showed they could **subdue coastal forts** with naval gunfire. This suggested that the river forts defending access to New Orleans might be overcome with **a naval attack supported by troop landings**. Both these previous operations had strengthened the Union blockade of the South's ports (see [Blockading the South](#)).

Union plans for an attack on New Orleans began in the winter of 1861–62. Initial estimates called for up to 50,000 Union troops. However, by February 1862, the main role had passed to the Union Navy's West Coast Blockading Squadron under Captain David Farragut.

Farragut chose to plan a purely naval operation to breach New Orleans' only serious defenses, forts Jackson and St. Philip. Sited on opposite sides of the Mississippi around 75 miles (120km) south of New Orleans, the forts held an estimated 126 guns. Conventional wisdom believed that warships trying to pass them would be blown out of the water. The Union squadron would also have to take on assorted ironclads and "cottonclads"—ships with cotton bales attached as a form of armor. In March, Farragut moved 17 ships past the initial obstacle: the sandbars that lay at the mouth of the Mississippi. Farragut's squadron included his flagship USS *Hartford*, and some mortar schooners for land bombardments. He then took a month to prepare. The Confederate forts were scouted, as was the chain of sunken hulks, stretching from bank to bank, intended to block passage up the river.

The bombardment began on April 18. Thousands of shells rained down on the forts, but the effects were minimal. Return fire from